

Coercion in Relationships Online



BIG IDEA Care does not look like control. Healthy relationships of any kind respect privacy, choice and “no.” Digital tools can be used to monitor, isolate and pressure, and there are clear signs and clear places to get help.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

COUNSELOR HEADS-UP FIRST + OPT-OUT PLAN Plan shared with the counselor and an administrator 5 school days ahead; counselor on site during and 2 hours after. Reporting route in writing. Pre-notice done; opt-outs do “Boundaries, Privacy and Pressure Among Friends and in Group Chats” (R7-Alt).

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R7 Line-Up Statement Cards, Help Map and Helpline Card per student (opt-outs too), a green, yellow and red card per student (or G, Y, R on paper), Workbook W7.

- ☐ Help Maps and Helpline Cards printed; opt-out room set.
- ☐ Board: “Consent is freely given, specific, ongoing, and can be withdrawn.”
- ☐ Say “partner,” assume nothing about orientation, never advise confronting a partner.

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN The Line-Up

- 1 (1 min) Set the code.** **Green** healthy. **Yellow** it depends. **Red** control or coercion. Statements, not people. Votes are private: cards up on three, or write G, Y or R and tally.
- 2 (4 min) Six statements**, 40 seconds each; one reason, then reveal. S1 location shared by choice, either can turn it off (green). S2 “They check my phone every night because they love me” (red). S3 swapped passwords to show trust (yellow). S4 “Send a photo or I will leave and tell people” (red). S5 a photo deleted on request (green). S6 a private chat posted to embarrass me (red).
- 3 (2 min) Signs of digital control:** constant checking, demanding passwords or locations, controlling who you talk to, pressure for images, threats to share, guilt. Help Map: loveisrespect (1-866-331-9474), 988, Crisis Text Line, 911.
- 4 (1 min) Boundary sentence**, aloud: “I’m not comfortable with that. I’m saying no.” If you suspect monitoring, do not confront; use a device they cannot see.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Why can controlling behavior feel like love at first? What is the tell?”
- 2** “What does a good friend say to someone going through this?”
- 3** “Where is your line on sharing location or passwords?”

1 HOOK 2 MIN 60-second script Say: “Trust means you can say no, have privacy, and say ‘I am busy’ without a fight. Sometimes control sneaks in disguised as care: ‘I just worry about you,’ ‘If you trusted me you would show me.’ Online tools make control easy: checking your phone, tracking your location. Today we practice telling caring from controlling, in any relationship, with made-up statements. Nobody says anything about their own life. If you are ever in a situation like this, it is not your fault, and there are people who can help.”

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “Pause when love or loyalty is used as a reason to give up your privacy or choice. Check whether you can say no safely. Tell a friend, a trusted adult or a hotline, before it is ‘bad enough.’ Add: ‘My boundary sentence is _____, and the person or place I would Tell is _____.’”

Hand signal: Hackles up? Unease about a request for your privacy counts (hand brushed up the neck, optional). Post it: “Care leaves room for no.”

EXIT TICKET “Write one sign of digital control from today and one place or person to go to for help.”

FUN BOOST Boundary Sentence Studio. Write one boundary three ways (light, firm, serious); trade with a neighbor.

LEVEL-UP Healthy Agreement. A one-page agreement for any friend group: what we share, what stays private, how we say no.

DIFFERENTIATE A pictured traffic-light scale, fewer statements, boundary-sentence cards.

FAMILY CARD Say: “You can say no to anyone, and you can always tell me if something feels off. You will not be in trouble.” Immediate danger: 911.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** “Thank you for telling me. You are not in trouble, and this is not your fault.”
- “What you describe is not okay, and you deserve to feel safe.”
- “I want to help you find the right people, and I will tell you what I am doing at each step.”
- **Do not say:** “Just break up with them.” “Why do you stay?” “Are you sure?”
- Do not tell the student to confront the person, or contact the person or family.
- Do not ask to see messages or images.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person before advising steps; follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law. Threats, stalking, violence, image threats, weapons or self-harm: same day. Danger: 911.